

Cinematic Poker

Sit down at a table that feels like a place. Six characters who bluff, tilt, talk and remember how you play. Offline, single-player — and we will never sell you chips.

The plan: own the niche of single players who want RDR2-style NPC poker as its own game, monetise with one-time content unlocks only (no real money, no card details, no ads), and deploy \$1,000 as ten measured experiments to find one repeatable acquisition channel.

\$1,000

Paid launch budget,
deployed as gated
experiments

\$12.8k

Base-case cumulative profit,
12 months post-launch

0

Chips sold · ads shown ·
card numbers touched

65M+

RDR2 copies sold — the
wedge audience's home

37k

Base-case year-one installs
(mobile)

M1

Base-case breakeven month

"RDR2 poker, as its own game" — a viable wedge

RDR2's saloon poker is one of gaming's most beloved minigames — not because the poker is deep (it isn't), but because of **diegetic immersion**: a table in a place, with characters who talk, react and exist. Players repeatedly ask for this as a standalone product. Nobody has shipped it.

Why the demand is real

Scale

RDR2 sold 65M+ copies. A sliver who loved the poker specifically outnumbers most indie audiences.

Explicit, repeated asks

r/reddeadredemption recurrently asks "what scratches the RDR2 poker itch?" — every answer today is unsatisfying. An unanswered recurring question in a large community is the cheapest marketing signal that exists.

Proven, then abandoned

Poker Night at the Inventory validated character-driven single-player poker, earned a sequel, then was delisted. A decade of demand, zero supply — never on mobile.

Risks & mitigations

IP Trademark exposure

"Red Dead" never appears in anything we control — product, store metadata, our ad copy. Comparisons live only in creator / community / press speech (legal editorial use). The public name stays **Cinematic Poker**.

EXPECTATIONS AAA fidelity gap

Build-in-public devlogs set honest expectations; we sell ambience, characters and tells — never graphics parity.

PRODUCT Deliver the fantasy at minute one

The Western 1860s saloon is promoted to **free flagship environment**. With environments-as-data this is a content re-ordering, not an engineering change.

Verdict: viable — the strongest available wedge. It unifies what the product already is (cinematic places, characters with tells and memory, offline single-player) under one instantly-understood promise, and it stacks with the anti-chip-casino counter-position: those apps are exactly what this player is fleeing.

Competitive landscape & our edge

COMPETITOR	MODEL	WEAKNESS WE EXPLOIT
Zynga Poker · WSOP · PokerStars Play	F2P chip casino, online	Chip sales, ads, connection required, zero table personality — loudly resented in their own reviews
Governor of Poker 3	F2P chip casino, campaign veneer	Abandoned the beloved paid single-player formula of GoP 1–2
Governor of Poker 1–2	Paid single-player	10+ years old, dated presentation, simplistic AI, no tells or coaching
Poker Night at the Inventory 1–2	Premium character poker (PC)	Delisted — validated demand, zero supply, never on mobile
Prominence Poker	F2P console/PC, online	Not mobile, not offline, not single-player-first
RDR2 itself	AAA; poker is a minigame	100GB install, no quick hand on the bus; shallow poker AI — ours is the actual product

Five defensible edges (features, not claims)

1 · Opponents with character

12-parameter AI personalities, tilt model, opponent memory (VPIP / PFR / 3-bet), probabilistic tells with false tells. Nobody on mobile has this.

2 · Offline-first

Flights, commutes, no account, no server — and "offline poker" is a high-intent, low-competition search cluster.

3 · Ethical monetisation

We sell *places*, never chips. A moral stance that doubles as the marketing hook.

4 · "Improve My Game" coaching

Hand-history review makes the game a poker trainer — a second audience and keyword cluster no competitor can copy.

5 · The web demo

A shareable, zero-install playable link running the identical engine. Every post, comment and email ends in "play it right now."

Counter-positioning is the only marketing strategy that works on \$1,000 — and we counter the entire category at once.

How we get paid — no real money, no card details

The constraint, honoured by design: in-game chips are score — they can never be bought, sold or cashed out, keeping us outside gambling licensing entirely (stores' "simulated gambling" category, 12+/Teen rating). All purchases are **one-time content unlocks via Apple / Google IAP**: the platforms process 100% of payments, and the app collects no account, no personal data, no payment data.

On iOS that earns the rare **"Data Not Collected"** privacy label — a genuine differentiator in a category famous for data harvesting. Put it in the screenshots.

Never: loot boxes, gacha, randomised monetisation, ads, subscriptions. Every purchase is a known thing at a known price.

Why free-to-download

Paid-up-front on a \$1,000 budget with no publisher means a few hundred installs and ranking death. Free removes the one friction we can't argue against, maximises the web-demo → store funnel, and "free, and we will never sell you chips" is itself the hook. Steam is the exception: desktop audiences reward premium pricing.

ITEM	PRICE
Base game — Western Saloon flagship, full engine, 5 NPCs, coaching, Mates' Kitchen second table	Free
Environment packs — a new place <i>and</i> a new NPC cast with new tells & dialogue (Kalgoorlie, Chicago 1926, Vegas, Disco 1978, Tokyo, Spaceport...); visitable before buying	\$3.99– 4.99
Everything Edition — all current and future environments; priced so two packs ≈ bundle	\$14.99 → \$19.99
Supporter tip — "buy the dealer a whisky"	\$2.99
Steam / desktop premium — everything included, ships M4; wishlists and Next Fest are free marketing	\$9.99

2–4%

of installs
become
payers

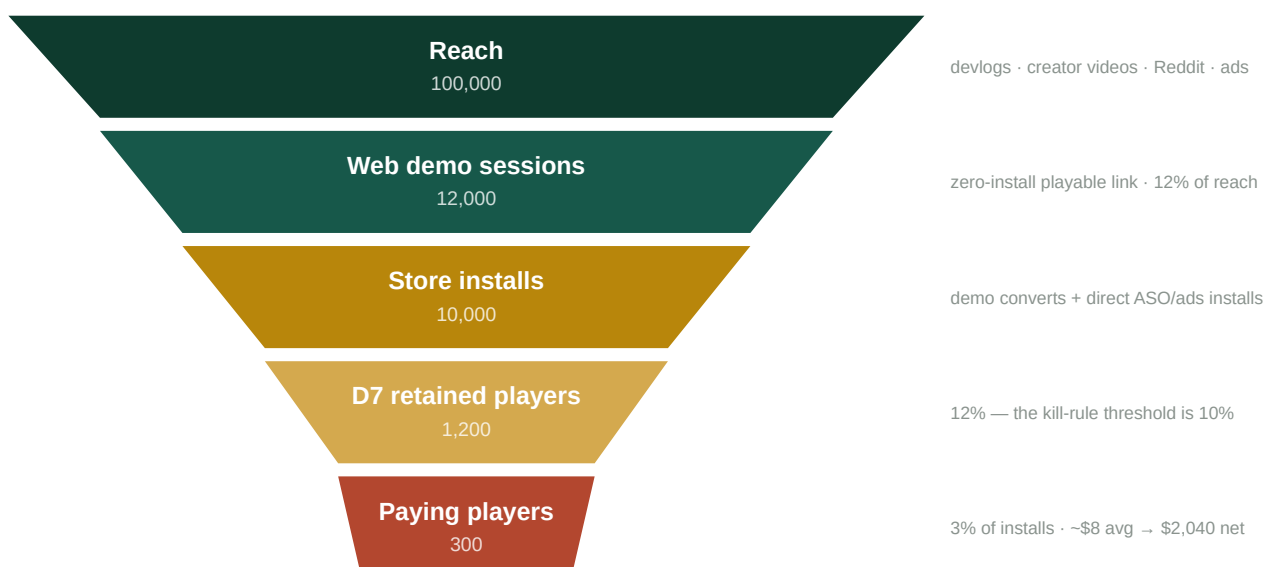
~\$8

avg revenue
per payer
(mobile)

**85% /
70%**

net kept —
mobile /
Steam

The acquisition funnel — base case, launch quarter (illustrative)



Budget allocation — ten experiments, hard kill rules

LINE	\$	KILL / SUCCESS GATE
Creator seeding — 20–25 poker + RDR2-adjacent micro-creators (5k–100k); \$25–50 paid for the 6–8 best fits; A/B the two framings	350	≥4 videos live in launch week; track which framing drives installs
Apple Search Ads — exact match only: offline poker, single player poker, poker vs ai, texas holdem offline, western / saloon poker	250	CPI < \$1.50 and D1 > 35%, else pause keyword
Reddit promoted posts — r/poker + mobile-gaming subs; western-gaming interest targeting, trademark never in our copy; destination = web demo	150	Median demo session > 2 min; demo → store CTR > 8%
Reserve — weeks 3–4, doubles down on the cheapest <i>retained</i> install	150	—
Trailer & assets — one 45s character-led trailer, reused everywhere	100	Exists before any spend

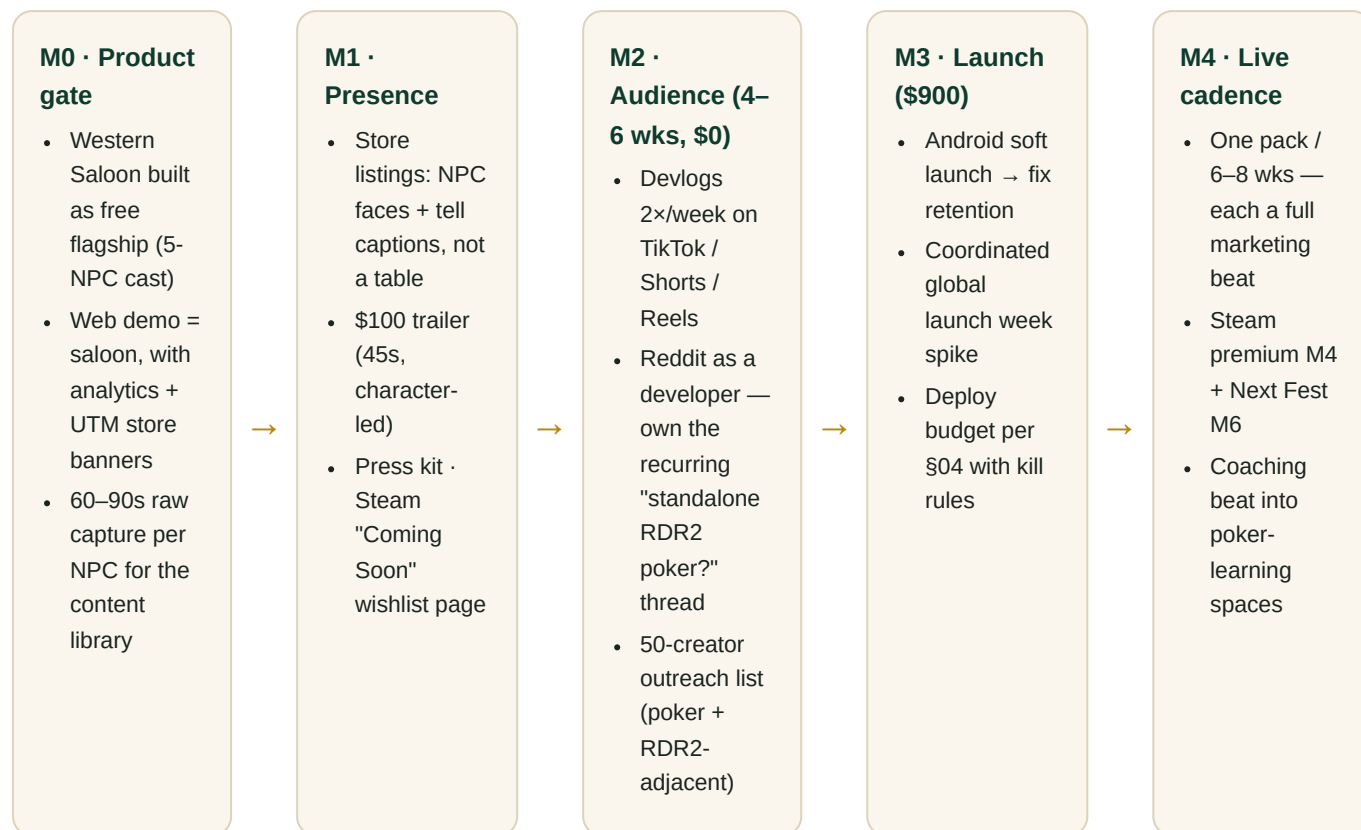


Deliberately \$0: Facebook/Google broad UA (viable minimums are 10–50× this budget), press agencies, paid reviews, feature brokers.

Free actions worth more than any paid line: twice-weekly devlogs, Reddit participation as a developer, press kit, pitching "best offline games" listicle authors, Steam wishlist page.

Global kill rule: any paid channel that cannot beat \$1.50 CPI with D7 > 10% after \$100 spent is stopped.

Roadmap — M0 to M4



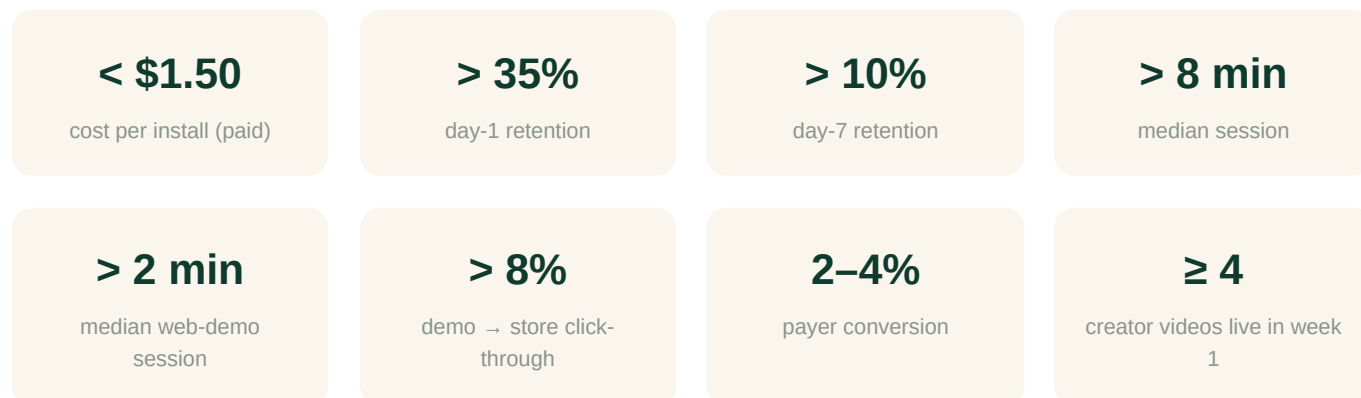
Gate A (blocks all spend): 3+ external testers each play the saloon 15–30 minutes unprompted **and can name the NPCs' personalities afterwards.**

Gate B (blocks global launch): soft-launch metrics — D1 > 35%, D7 > 10%, median session > 8 minutes.

The strategic A/B every launch asset answers

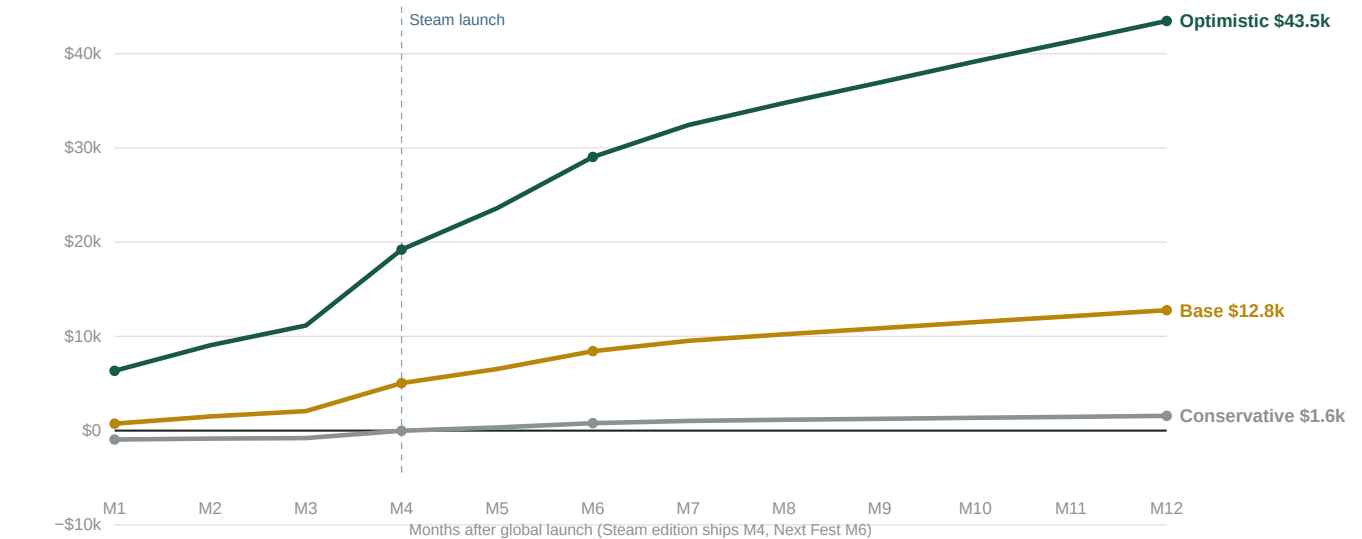
Does the **saloon-fantasy** framing or the **anti-chip-casino** framing acquire better-retaining players? Creator briefs and ad sets are split between the two; the winner leads every M4 beat.

Launch-week KPI targets



Projected profit over 12 months

Cumulative profit = mobile IAP net (85% after store small-business cut) + Steam net (70%) – \$1,250 upfront (ads, dev accounts, Steam Direct) – \$50/month running costs. Scenarios differ on install volume, payer conversion, average revenue per payer and Steam units.

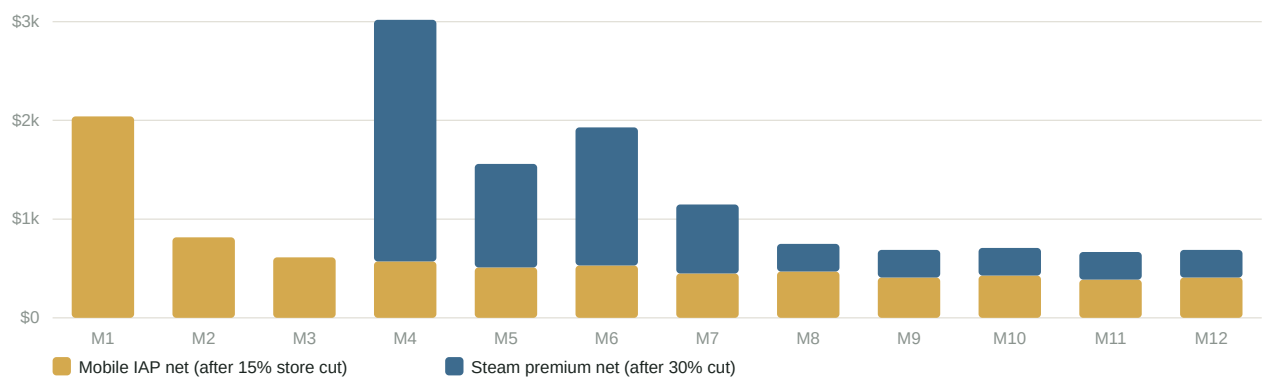


SCENARIO	INSTALLS (YR 1)	PAYER % · ARPPU	STEAM UNITS	CUMULATIVE PROFIT (M12)	BREAKEVEN
Conservative Launch lands quietly; no creator video takes off; organic floor only.	11,100	2% · \$7	300	\$1.6k	M5
Base Creator seeding produces a handful of mid-size videos; ASO cluster ranks; pack beats sustain a floor.	37,400	3% · \$8	1,000	\$12.8k	M1
Optimistic One creator video breaks out; the RDR2-itch framing spreads; Everything Edition attach rises.	91,000	4% · \$9	2,500	\$43.5k	M1

Because total cost is tiny, even the conservative case reaches breakeven — the real risk is opportunity cost, not capital. The budget's job is to find **one repeatable channel** (CPI < \$1.50, D7 > 10%); that evidence, not launch revenue, is what justifies real spend afterwards.

Base-case monthly net revenue mix

Mobile launch spike decays to an ASO + devlog floor sustained by pack beats every 6–8 weeks; the \$9.99 Steam edition lands month 4 with a Next Fest bump in month 6.



Risk register

RISK	MITIGATION
Fun bar not met	Gate A blocks all marketing spend until the saloon slice passes the 15–30 minute test with nameable NPC personalities
IP exposure	No third-party names or assets anywhere we control; comparisons live only in editorial / creator / community speech; repo name stays private
Poker flagged as gambling by ad platforms	Creatives lead with "no real money, no chips for sale"; simulated-gambling store questionnaires completed correctly from day one
Expectation gap vs AAA	Honest build-in-public devlogs; sell ambience and characters, never graphics parity
Web-demo cannibalisation	Acceptable — it converts sceptics; keep one pack store-exclusive if the data shows a problem

Measurement

UTM-tag every link; two funnels (web demo → store, store direct). Weekly dashboard: installs by source, CPI, D1/D7, median session, % reaching hand 10, payer conversion, pack attach rate, Everything-Edition take rate, Steam wishlists. The strategic A/B — saloon fantasy vs anti-chip-casino — is settled with launch-week data and leads all future beats.